

Beliefs about Refugee Integration in Germany: A Survey Experiment on Ukrainian and Syrian Refugees

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1 Introduction

2 Literature Review and Conceptual Framework

2.1 Immigration Attitudes and Migrant Characteristics

A large literature examines how host-country populations evaluate migrants and which characteristics shape these evaluations. One central distinction in this literature is based on whether attitudes toward migrants primarily reflect individuals' own economic interests and labor-market considerations or characteristics of the migrants.

Earlier economic studies provide some evidence that labor-market considerations are associated with immigration preferences (e.g., Scheve and Slaughter, 2001; Mayda, 2006). Other studies, however, emphasize the importance of welfare concerns, cultural considerations, and group-related attitudes rather than just individual labor-market interests (Burns and Gimpel, 2000; Dustmann and Preston, 2007; Sides and Citrin, 2007). Reviewing this literature, Hainmueller and Hopkins (2014) conclude that evidence for explanations based on individual economic self-interest is generally limited, particularly compared with broader sociotropic economic and cultural concerns.

Experimental evidence further challenges a simple labor-market competition explanation and rather points to the importance of migrants' own characteristics. Hainmueller and Hiscox (2010) find that both high- and low-skilled natives prefer high-skilled over low-skilled immigrants. If immigration attitudes were primarily driven by competition with similarly skilled workers, preferences would be expected to differ according to respondents' own skill levels. Instead, the common preference for high-skilled immigration suggests that respondents place considerable weight on migrants' human capital and potential economic contribution. This pattern is also found in multidimensional experiments. Higher education, occupational status, employability, and language proficiency are generally associated with more favorable evaluations of migrants (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; Bansak et al., 2016; Czymara and Schmidt-Catran, 2016). More recent evidence from Germany similarly shows greater willingness to accept skilled labor migrants with recognized professional qualifications, good language skills, and a definite job offer (Wolff et al., 2025). Taken together, these studies show that characteristics associated with migrants' expected labor-market integration play an important role in how they are evaluated by the host-country population.

However, evaluations of migrants are not determined by human capital alone. Country of origin, cultural and religious background, and migration status also influence attitudes when other characteristics are held constant. Hainmueller and Hopkins (2015) find differences in evaluations across immigrants' countries of origin alongside effects of education, occupation, and English proficiency. In the European context, Bansak et al. (2016) show that preferences over asylum seekers depend jointly on economic, humanitarian, and cultural characteristics, with country of origin and religion affecting support in addition

to employability and vulnerability. Similar patterns emerge in Germany. Czymara and Schmidt-Catran (2016) find that acceptance varies with migrants’ country of origin and migration motive as well as their education and German-language proficiency. These findings suggest that respondents evaluate migrants based on both individual characteristics and the broader groups and migration categories to which they belong. One possible explanation for the importance of such group-level characteristics is provided by theories of group position and perceived group threat. Quillian (1995), building on the group-position perspective of Blumer (1958), argues that prejudice toward immigrant groups can be related to perceived collective threat and the relative position of the in-group and out-group. In the European context, such perceptions are associated with factors including the relative size of immigrant groups and economic conditions. This perspective suggests that evaluations of migrants may partly reflect how migrant groups and their position within the host society are perceived.

Despite their differences, much of this literature shares a focus on attitudes and preferences toward migrants. Outcomes commonly concern support for immigration, willingness to admit or accept migrants, or preferences regarding their residence and employment. These outcomes capture how respondents evaluate migrants, but they do not necessarily reveal what respondents believe about migrants’ likely outcomes. Attitudes and expectations are conceptually distinct. For example, a respondent may be willing to accept a refugee while expecting that the person will face difficulties finding employment or integrating socially. Conversely, a respondent may oppose further immigration while nevertheless expecting a particular migrant to succeed economically. Understanding how migrant characteristics affect beliefs about expected outcomes therefore requires examining these expectations directly, which is what I aim to do in this thesis.

This thesis focuses on what outcomes respondents expect different migrants to experience, rather than on whether they are willing to accept them. I examine expectations concerning employment, occupational match, future income, discrimination, and social integration. The proposed factorial design makes it possible to examine whether these expectations vary with migrant characteristics, while also testing whether otherwise comparable migrants are evaluated differently. The next section develops this distinction further by reviewing the literature on beliefs, expectations, and misperceptions about migrants.

2.2 Beliefs and Expectations about Migrant Outcomes

A growing literature shows that individuals hold systematic beliefs about immigrants and their economic and social characteristics. Much of this research examines perceptions of immigrant populations as a whole, including their size, composition, education, and employment (Sides and Citrin, 2007; Alesina et al., 2023). Respondents tend to overestimate the share of immigrants living in their country, and perceive immigrants as less educated, more unemployed, and more dependent on government transfers than they actually are.

Moreover, these perceptions may depend on which types of migrants respondents have in mind. Blinder (2015) shows that public understandings of the term “immigrant” do not necessarily correspond to the full migrant population, with some migrant categories being considerably more salient than others. This suggests that treating migrants as a single category may obscure differences in how distinct types of migrants are perceived. Consistent with this argument, experimental evidence from Germany shows that evaluations also vary with migrants’ reasons for migration (Czymara and Schmidt-Catran, 2016). In my thesis, I therefore propose to distinguish explicitly between refugees and labor migrants.

Much of the literature on beliefs about migrants focuses on aggregate characteristics of the migrant population as the ones mentioned above. These beliefs are different from expectations about the future outcomes of individual migrants. A related literature examines migrants’ employability and labor-market experiences and shows that employment outcomes depend not only on migrants’ individual characteristics, but also on organizational and institutional factors in the host country (Shirmohammadi et al., 2019; Farashah et al., 2023). In particular, research on immigrant recruitment shows that employers’ perceptions and evaluations can influence the employment opportunities of migrant applicants (Almeida et al., 2015; Te Nijenhuis et al., 2014; Fernando et al., 2016), while other studies document discrimination and disadvantages in employment and occupational outcomes among skilled migrants (Dietz et al., 2015; Rafferty, 2012; Karlsen, 2012; Faaliyat et al., 2021). However, these studies mostly examine migrants’ actual labor-market experiences or employers’ recruitment decisions, often focusing on skilled migrants and specific groups of evaluators such as employers and recruiters, rather than the expectations of the broader host-country population. My thesis differs from this previous literature in its focus on what a broader sample of German respondents expect the labor-market and social outcomes to be of refugees and labor migrants with different skill levels, origin, gender, and education. These expectations would naturally include how they expect the employers and recruiters in their country to assess migrant applicants within the scope of their organizational and institutional factors.

A smaller literature comes closer to examining such expectations from the perspective of the host-country population. Niemann et al. (2024), for example, study how working adults in Germany form expectations about migrants’ occupational future and integration efforts depending on migrant characteristics such as origin, skill level, and migration status. Related research demonstrates that individuals also hold beliefs about the discrimination experienced by migrants. Haaland and Roth (2023) document substantial differences in how much discrimination respondents believe occurs in hiring in the United States. Although their study concerns racial discrimination rather than migration, it provides an important distinction between beliefs about discrimination and actual discriminatory behavior. Together, these studies show that employment prospects, integration, and treatment in the labor market can be studied as subjective expectations

held by others.

Nevertheless, relatively little is known about the beliefs regarding labor-market and social outcomes of the common host-country population on different types of migrants. Existing literature generally examine particular expectations separately, as the ones stated above, whereas employment, occupational match, income, discrimination, and social integration may capture different aspects of migrants' expected integration and labor-market success. The proposed experiment in this thesis addresses this gap by revealing German respondents' expectations across these different outcomes for hypothetical migrants whose characteristics are independently varied. This makes it possible to examine whether migrant characteristics affect expected outcomes.

2.3 Differential Perceptions of Ukrainian and Syrian Migrants

Earlier literature shows that responses to refugees in Germany already differed across groups and changed over time during and after the 2015–2016 refugee inflow. In particular, country of origin was associated with differences in acceptance of refugees, while other characteristics such as migration circumstances and family composition also shaped public responses (Bansak et al., 2016; Czymara and Schmidt-Catran, 2016, 2017; Plener et al., 2017; Liebe et al., 2018). Czymara and Schmidt-Catran (2017), for example, show that following the events of New Year's Eve 2015/2016, the acceptance of refugees generally increased, whereas the acceptance of immigrants of North African and Arab origin declined. Other research demonstrates that attitudes also varied with local exposure to the refugee inflow. Albarosa and Elsner (2023), for instance, document heterogeneous changes in attitudes across German regions depending on the size of the local refugee inflow. Looking at a later period, Przechomski et al. (2026) find that, after an initial increase in negative sentiment, attitudes gradually became more positive between 2017 and 2021.

The arrival of Ukrainian refugees following Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022 provided a new context for examining differences in responses to refugee groups in Europe. Existing research demonstrates that Ukrainian refugees have generally received more favorable public and institutional responses than Syrian refugees (Moise et al., 2024; Drewski and Gerhards, 2025; Das, 2025). Evidence from Germany similarly shows greater willingness to help Ukrainian refugees, more positive perceptions of their warmth and integration prospects, and greater solidarity toward them than toward Syrian refugees (Echterhoff et al., 2023; Schmidt et al., 2024; Stefaniak et al., 2025). These findings therefore suggest that public responses are shaped not only by refugee status itself but also by refugees' country of origin.

Several explanations have been proposed for these differences. The responses toward Ukrainian and Syrian refugees depend on how the two groups are perceived, including their cultural similarity to the host population, the threat they are perceived to pose, and how deserving they are considered to be (Echterhoff et al., 2023; Schmidt et al., 2024; Stefaniak

et al., 2025). At the broader political level, Drewski and Gerhards (2025) show that Syrian and Ukrainian refugees were framed differently in Germany and Poland and link these differences to cultural and geopolitical factors that shaped state responses to the two groups. Taken together, this evidence suggests that country of origin is associated with a broader set of group-level perceptions that cannot be reduced to refugees’ observable individual characteristics alone.

Building on this literature, this thesis aims to examine whether the documented differences in perceptions of Ukrainian and Syrian migrants are accompanied by differences in specific beliefs about their labor-market outcomes. Existing studies differ from mine because they examine outcomes such as acceptance, solidarity, willingness to help, perceived threat, or general integration prospects. It is important to distinguish beliefs about concrete economic and social integration outcomes from general attitudes, as more favorable attitudes toward a migrant group do not necessarily imply more favorable expectations regarding its economic and social integration. This thesis therefore focuses on beliefs about the integration outcomes of Ukrainian and Syrian migrants in Germany.

2.4 Contact, Personal Experience, Information, and Memory

We know a great deal about attitudes toward different migrant profiles; there is growing evidence on beliefs and expectations; we know that Ukrainians and Syrians are perceived and received differently; and separately we know that contact, experience, information, and memory can be related to beliefs. What remains less understood is how otherwise comparable Ukrainian and Syrian refugees and labor migrants are expected to fare in Germany and how these group-specific expectations relate to respondents’ prior experiences and information environments.

3 Experimental Design

The study employs a factorial vignette experiment in which respondents evaluate hypothetical migrants whose characteristics are independently varied across profiles. This approach is particularly suitable for the present research question because migrants differ simultaneously along several characteristics, such as country of origin, migration status, skill level, and language proficiency. Factorial designs allow the effects of these characteristics to be distinguished by independently varying them while holding the remaining characteristics constant. The proposed design builds on previous conjoint and factorial vignette experiments examining how migrant characteristics affect evaluations by host-country populations (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2015; Bansak et al., 2016; Czymara and Schmidt-Catran, 2016).

- i indexes respondents.
- j indexes vignette profiles.

- $g \in \{\text{Ukraine, Syria}\}$ indexes migrant groups.
- Y_{ij} denotes respondent i 's evaluation of vignette j .
- C_{ig} denotes respondent i 's contact exposure to migrant group g .
- Q_{ig} denotes respondent i 's overall contact quality with migrant group g .
- M_{ig} denotes respondent i 's media exposure regarding migrant group g .

General Notation: For inline equations, use For displayed equations, use

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or the equation environment.

3.1 Target Population and Proposed Sample

3.2 Factorial Vignette Design

The study employs a factorial vignette experiment in which respondents evaluate hypothetical migrants whose characteristics are independently varied across profiles. This approach builds on previous factorial and conjoint experiments examining how characteristics of immigrants and refugees affect evaluations by host-country populations (e.g., Hainmueller & Hopkins, 2015; Bansak et al., 2016; Czymara & Schmidt-Catran, 2016).

The vignettes describe potential migrants who currently live in Germany and differ randomly across several characteristics. The description of immigrants is based on a total of five dimensions: country of origin (Ukrainian/Syrian), reason for immigration (war refugee/labor migrant), gender (male/female), language skills (low/good German), and education (low/high). Country and language skills describe the cultural distance. Distinguish between two levels: (1) low and (2) good German language skills. The education factor represents the human capital of the immigrants. Distinguish between a (1) low and a (2) high level of education, where: low level of education: completed secondary education but has no vocational or university degree. high level of education: has a university degree. It should also be taken into account that language skills also have an economic component. Success in the labor market depends, for example, on the ability to speak the local language. The effect size of language proficiency could exceed the effect sizes of religious affiliation and country of origin. However, it should be considered that part of the effect of language skills, in the sense of the human capital hypothesis, can also be attributed to economic considerations. (Czymara & Schmidt-Catran, 2016)

Why religious affiliation is not included in the vignette: As discussed in the literature review, previous research demonstrates that religion and perceived cultural distance can influence attitudes toward immigrants (e.g., Czymara & Schmidt-Catran, 2016). However, in this study, religious affiliation is deliberately not included as a randomized vignette

attribute. The present study focuses on differences in expectations associated with migrants' country of origin, migration status, human capital, gender, and German-language proficiency. Introducing religion as an additional vignette dimension would increase the complexity of the experimental design. Moreover, explicitly providing information about religious affiliation could alter the beliefs that respondents would otherwise associate with Ukrainian and Syrian migrants based on the country of origin alone. Religion is therefore left unspecified in the vignette, allowing the country-of-origin treatment to capture respondents' overall beliefs associated with the respective national-origin group. Consequently, the estimated country-of-origin effect should be interpreted as a composite effect that may encompass perceived cultural and religious differences, rather than as an effect of nationality that is independent of religion. Respondents' own religious affiliation is nevertheless collected as a background characteristic and can be included as a control or examined in heterogeneity analyses.

Vignette wording: [Gender: Mr./Mrs.] [random letter]. came from [country of origin: Ukraine/Syria] to Germany. [He/She] came to Germany as [reason for immigration: a refugee after fleeing the war in [his/her] country / a labor migrant seeking employment opportunities in Germany]. [He/She] [skill level: has completed a university degree / has no formal vocational qualification], speaks German [language skills: well / only to a limited extent] and is currently looking for stable employment.

vignette universe: $2 \times 2 \times 2 \times 2 \times 2 = 32$ profiles

male/female $\times$ Ukraine/Syria $\times$ refugee/labor migrant $\times$ high/low skill $\times$ good/limited German = 16 profiles

Each respondent receives only a few randomly selected vignettes. The randomization allows estimation of the marginal effect of each characteristic.

1. Explained vignette attributes: *Origin_j MigrationStatus_j Gender_j Education_j GermanSkills_j*

2. Choosing particular vignette attributes: Educational attainment is included because previous vignette and conjoint evidence consistently documents more favorable evaluations of highly skilled immigrants (Hainmueller & Hiscox, 2010; Hainmueller & Hopkins, 2015; Czymara & Schmidt-Catran, 2016). Language proficiency can be connected to Czymara & Schmidt-Catran and other relevant experiments. Migration status can be justified through the refugee-versus-labor-migrant literature. Country of origin obviously comes from your substantive Ukrainian–Syrian research question.

3.3 Outcomes Measures

3.4 Respondent Questionnaire

Citing measurement sources for the respondent questionnaire: C_{ig}^{Work} workplace contact frequency C_{ig}^{Social} social contact frequency Q_{ig} contact quality

Contact quality: The notation $Q_{ig} \in \{1, \dots, 7\}$ denotes respondent i 's overall contact

quality with migrant group g . Contact quality is measured on a 7-point scale, where 1 indicates very negative contact experiences and 7 indicates very positive contact experiences. The measure is adapted to distinguish between the two origin groups examined in the present study.

$$PositiveExperience_{ig} = \max(Q_{ig} - 4, 0)$$

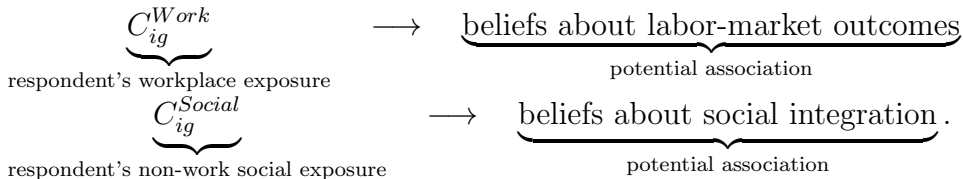
$$NegativeExperience_{ig} = \max(4 - Q_{ig}, 0)$$

Following the intergroup-contact literature, the questionnaire distinguishes between the frequency and quality of respondents' contact with members of the two origin groups. This distinction is motivated by previous evidence showing that the quantity and valence of intergroup contact constitute conceptually distinct dimensions and may have different relationships with attitudes toward refugees (e.g., De Coninck et al., 2021). Contact is measured separately for Ukrainians and Syrians and across workplace and non-work social settings.

Media exposure: $MediaExposure_{ig}$ Media exposure is measured separately for Ukrainian and Syrian refugees. Building on work conceptualizing refugee-related media exposure as a form of indirect intergroup contact (e.g., De Coninck et al., 2021), respondents report the frequency with which they encounter relevant news and media coverage. The measure is adapted to distinguish between the two origin groups examined in the present study.

Motivated by research showing that the memorability of information and narratives may influence subsequent beliefs (Graeber et al., 2024), the questionnaire additionally elicits whether respondents can recall a particularly salient personal experience involving members of either origin group and, if so, the valence of that experience.

Belief about migrant integration:



Beliefs about large communities and network effects:

Large community $\rightarrow$ More information/referrals $\rightarrow$ Better employment
versus

Large community $\rightarrow$ Less native interaction $\rightarrow$ Slower integration.

Construct:

$$\Delta B_i^{Network} = B_{i,S}^{Network} - B_{i,U}^{Network}$$

3.5 Randomization and Survey Procedure

4 Empirical Strategy and Identification

Identification and equations: Baseline equation:

$$Y_{ij} = \alpha + \beta_1 Ukr_j + \beta_2 Ref_j + \beta_3 Female_j + \beta_4 HighSkill_j + \beta_5 German_j + \varepsilon_{ij}.$$

Adjusted specification:

$$Y_{ij} = \alpha + \beta_1 Ukr_j + \beta_2 Ref_j + \beta_3 Female_j + \beta_4 HighSkill_j + \beta_5 German_j + \boldsymbol{\delta}'\mathbf{X}_i + \varepsilon_{ij}.$$

H4 regression with interaction term:

$$Y_{ij} = \alpha + \beta_1 Ukraine_j + \beta_2 Refugee_j + \beta_3 (Ukraine_j \times Refugee_j) + \boldsymbol{\gamma}'\mathbf{Z}_j + \varepsilon_{ij}.$$

where

$$\mathbf{Z}_j = \begin{pmatrix} Female_j \\ HighSkill_j \\ GoodGerman_j \end{pmatrix}$$

$$\mathbf{X}_i = (Age_i, Gender_i, Edu_i, Emp_i, Inc_i, Mig_i, East_i, Religion_i, Right_i)'.$$

Then,

$$Y_{ij} = \alpha + \boldsymbol{\beta}'\mathbf{Z}_j + \boldsymbol{\theta}'\mathbf{X}_i + \varepsilon_{ij},$$

where $\boldsymbol{\theta}$ is the vector of coefficients associated with the respondent controls, and $\mathbf{Z}_j$ is contains the randomized vignette characteristics and $\mathbf{X}_i$ contains respondent-level controls.

5 Limitations and Extensions

5.1 Extensions

5.2 Limitations and Identification Constraints

6 Conclusion

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Statement of Authorship

I hereby confirm that the work presented has been performed and interpreted solely by myself except for where I explicitly identified the contrary. I assure that this work has not been presented in any other form for the fulfillment of any other degree or qualification. Ideas taken from other works in letter and in spirit are identified in every single case.

Date:

Signature: